



PRESIDENTIAL LEGACY WEBSITE · PLAN V3 · FINAL ADDENDUM

The Human *Standard*

Typography, soul, and the end of the robotic web page. An execution addendum that overrides the visual layer of the Pro Max plan — the story spine, scene engine and performance gates remain law.

Why the current build reads as robotic

The bones are right — the spine, the scene engine, the evidence architecture. What fails is the surface: it is executed like an engineer's idea of elegance. These are the ten tells, each with its correction. Every one is binding.

ROBOTIC TELL (PRESENT TODAY)	HUMAN CORRECTION (BUILD THIS)
1 • Monospace everywhere. Letter-spaced uppercase mono on every label reads terminal, not state.	Demote mono to ≤ 1 appearance per viewport (frame metadata only). Labels become sentence-case sans or true small-caps serif.
2 • Dead-flat pure black. #050505 everywhere is a void, not a room.	Warm layered blacks (#0B0906 → #14100A) with one consistent light source, gentle vignettes, tonal steps between planes.
3 • 1px gold lines as the only decoration. Thin strokes on black = crypto dashboard.	Gold becomes <i>material</i> : gradient sheen inside monumental numerals, foil-weight rules (2–3px, short), engraved borders — and far fewer of them.
4 • Perfect symmetry. Every block centered or evenly split; nothing overlaps anything.	Asymmetric compositions; one deliberate grid-break per chapter (an image crossing a column, a numeral hanging into a margin).
5 • Uniform section rhythm. eyebrow → h2 → content, eleven times.	Vary the metre: dense evidence chapters separated by quiet full-bleed photographic interludes with a single line of text.
6 • Photography imprisoned in boxes. Every image is a small framed rectangle.	Let the strongest photograph in each chapter run full-bleed or two-thirds bleed, art-directed and graded; boxes only for the filmstrip.
7 • One reveal animation for everything. Same fade-up, same delay grid.	Choreography per chapter: numerals rise heavier, quotes breathe in slower, frames settle with 8px weight. Same easing family, different sentences.
8 • Template copy voice. Headings that could be any product page.	Editorial voice: drop caps on narrative openings, pull-lines between sections, captions written like a curator.
9 • No texture. Flat fills behind everything.	Paper grain on light planes, photographic atmosphere behind dark planes, subtle ink-bleed on display type where supported.
10 • Everything the same width. One max-width container, centered.	Three measures in play (narrow ceremony 44ch, text 68ch, full-bleed), marginalia allowed, hanging elements allowed.

THE LAW

If a viewport could plausibly be a screenshot from a template marketplace or an AI demo, it is rejected — regardless of how clean it is. Cleanliness is not the standard. Intention is.

Better fonts, chosen like a book designer

Verified: Google Fonts is reachable from the build environment (css2 API + gstatic files). Claude Code must download, subset and self-host these — never hotlink. The site keeps zero external requests.

ROLE	PRIMARY CHOICE	FALLBACK CHOICE	USAGE LAW
Display serif ceremony, H1/H2, monumental numerals	Cormorant Garamond 500/600 + italics — high-contrast galalde; statesmanlike, luxurious, sharp	Playfair Display; or keep Fraunces at 500 (never 900)	Tight tracking (−0.5% to −2%), generous size. Italic only for thesis lines and pull quotes.
Text serif narrative body, quotes, captions-long	Newsreader 400/500 + italic (opsz variable — set small optical sizes for body)	Source Serif 4; Libre Caslon Text	Body 17–19px/1.65, measure 60–68ch. This is what makes it read as a printed record, not an app.
Sans UI, nav, data labels, small captions	Instrument Sans 400/500/600	Public Sans; keep Hanken Grotesk	Sentence case by default. Uppercase only at ≤11px with +8% tracking, sparingly.
Mono frame metadata only	IBM Plex Mono 400	Space Mono (current)	≤ one appearance per viewport. Never for headings, labels, buttons or navigation.

Micro-typography laws

- Real quotation marks (“ ” ‘ ’) and real dashes (— -). Straight quotes are a defect.
- `font-variant-numeric: oldstyle-nums` in running text; `tabular-nums lining-nums` in the Ledger.
- Fluid scale: `--step-N: clamp()` ratio ~1.25 mobile → ~1.333 desktop; no arbitrary sizes.
- Display leading 0.95–1.05; text 1.55–1.7; captions 1.4.
- `text-wrap`: balance on headings; hanging-punctuation: first where supported.
- Never fake small-caps. Use `font-variant-caps` or a face that has them.

Self-host pipeline (Claude Code runs this)

```
1. curl the css2 URL with a Chrome UA:
   fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=

Cormorant+Garamond:ital,wght@0,500;0,600;1,500
2. Download each latin woff2 from
   fonts.gstatic.com
3. pip install fonttools brotli && pyftsubset
   --flavor=woff2 --layout-features=kern,liga,
   onum,tnum,smcp --unicodes=U+0000-
   00FF,U+2013-2019,
   U+2026,U+00D7,U+2192
4. Base64-embed (site stays one file, zero
   requests)
5. Preload nothing except the two faces used
   above the fold; font-display: swap
```

Weight budget: full replacement stack subsetting ≈ 180–260 KB — comparable to the current embedded set.

How a chapter should feel set

Approximate render (this PDF uses the current fonts; the build uses the new stack).

Judge the relationships, not the letterforms.

The National Ledger

Forty years, measured in national capacity

From a nation in ruins to a nation on the rise.

Electricity generation

60 → 2,048 MW

From a single ageing dam to Karuma, Isimba
and a grid with surplus for the region — the
record in one line of light.

Note what is absent: no uppercase mono, no thin full-width rules, no boxes. Hierarchy is carried
by size, weight, colour temperature and space alone.

From flat surfaces to lit rooms

The dark canvas stays. But black must behave like a photographed material — velvet, stone, night air — not a fill value.

TOKEN	VALUE	BEHAVIOUR
--night	#0B0906	Base canvas. Never pure #000/#050505 — warm it.
--night-2 / -3	#120D08 / #1A140C	Raised planes and panels; tonal steps replace border boxes.
--ivory / -2	#F1E9D6 / #C9BFA6	Text. Two temperatures only; no grey text on black, ever.
--gold-foil	linear-gradient(105°, #8C6A24, #E3C46A 45%, #9C7A2E)	Inside monumental numerals and the seal — gold with light in it.
--gold-line	#C9A24A at 35-55%	Short rules ($\leq 80\text{px}$) and keylines only. Full-width hairlines are rationed to two per chapter.
--clay / --leaf	#8E1117 / #2F5C2F	Ceremonial accents; never fields of colour.

Light logic

- One key light per chapter, upper-centre or horizon-low. Every glow, shadow and image grade obeys it.
- Vignette the stage corners 8-12% so the canvas curves away like a room.
- Photographs get one grade: warm shadows lifted toward #17110B, highlights toward ivory — the same air in every frame.

Texture recipe

- Grain: current SVG turbulence tile at 4-6% — keep.
- Add: a second, larger-scale mottle (radial-gradient clusters at 2-3%) so surfaces read as paper/stone, not noise.
- Dark chapters: a barely-there photographic atmosphere layer (out-of-focus landscape at 4-8%) behind the Ledger and Voices.

GOLD LAW

Gold is a metal, not a colour. If it doesn't look like it would catch light, it doesn't ship.

Asymmetry, overlap, and varied metre

Humans design with tension; templates design with equality. Rebuild each chapter's composition to these rules.

CHAPTER	COMPOSITION DIRECTIVE (ONE GRID-BREAK EACH, MARKED ♦)
Hero	Title block sits lower-left third; portrait large right, ♦ his hat brim allowed to break the masthead line. Thesis hangs into left margin. Proof strip peeks.
Inheritance	"1986" numeral at 40vh set half-off the left edge ♦; copy in a narrow 44ch column right of centre; one sepia photograph bleeding off the bottom.
Ledger	Numerals ragged-right at varying indents (ledger-book feel), not a uniform grid; the gold axis broken where each figure interrupts it ♦.
Journey	Era cards at alternating vertical offsets ($\pm 24\text{px}$) along the track ♦; active era physically larger, neighbours dimmed and desaturated.
Atlas	Break the 3x2: one dominant plate spans 2x2 with a full-bleed image ♦, four supporting plates around it. Rotate dominance per build.
Regions	Map bleeds off the right edge ♦; evidence panel overlaps the map's western border by 40px, casting a soft shadow onto it.
Voices	Quotes at alternating measures and indents; opening word of each quote gets a 2-line drop cap ♦; portrait silhouette sits behind the text at 6%.
In Pictures	Frames at slight alternating baseline offsets like a hand-hung gallery wall ♦ ($\pm 6\text{px}$, not rotation — no scrapbook kitsch).
Interludes (new)	Between Ledger→Journey and Voices→Pictures: full-bleed graded photograph, one serif line, nothing else. The page breathes.

RHYTHM LAW

Dense, quiet, dense, quiet. If three consecutive viewports have the same information density, insert air or evidence — never another card.

Photography as testimony, not thumbnails

RULE	DIRECTIVE
Scale	Each chapter's strongest photograph earns $\geq 60\%$ of a viewport. Small images exist only inside the filmstrip.
One grade	Single duotone family: shadows #17110B, highlights toward ivory; CSS: <code>sepia(.25) saturate(.7) contrast(1.05) brightness(.92)</code> + a warm multiply scrim. All frames share the same air.
Crop psychology	Crop for subject dignity and direction of gaze — leave looking-room; never centre-crop by default. Set per-image <code>object-position</code> desktop and mobile.
Edges	Full-bleed images dissolve into the canvas with 80–140px gradient masks — no hard rectangle boundaries except the filmstrip.
Captions	Written like a curator: place · year · one clause of meaning. Set in text serif italic, not mono.
Wanted assets	Still required and worth acquiring: a genuine 1986–1990s archival photograph; the official coat of arms; one ceremonial/podium image; one landscape (dawn over the Nile) for interludes.

Choreography, not animation

MOMENT	SENTENCE (SAME EASING FAMILY — CUBIC-BEZIER(.16,1,.3,1) — DIFFERENT WEIGHT)
Ledger numeral	Rises 14px over 950ms as its counter runs — heavy, inevitable. Label follows 120ms later, lighter.
Voice quote	Fades over 900ms with 6px rise; drop cap arrives first, body second — like breath before speech.
Archive frame	Settles 10px with a $1^\circ \rightarrow 0^\circ$ micro-straighten, as if hung by hand.
Map nodes	Light in reading order (NW→SE) with 90ms stagger — a country waking, not a UI loading.
Interlude image	Scale 1.04 $\rightarrow$ 1.00 over 1400ms. Nothing else moves. Silence is part of the choreography.

Unchanged law: transform/opacity only · IntersectionObserver · reduced-motion = designed stillness · no scroll-jacking.

The loop that makes the frontend 100,000× better

The single highest-leverage rule: never judge the work from code. Render it, look at it, score it, refine it — no fewer than three full cycles before any ship.

STEP	ACTION	STANDARD
1	Audit	Read the repo, the plan, the asset inventory. List what exists, what’s missing, what’s weak.
2	Reference	Name 3 concrete references before designing (e.g. Obama Presidential Center, nobelprize.org laureate pages, NYT interactive features, Rijksmuseum). State what is being borrowed from each.
3	Tokens first	Type scale, colour, spacing, easing as CSS custom properties before any layout. No magic numbers later.
4	Build	Semantic HTML → composition → type → colour → motion, in that order.
5	Screenshot	Playwright renders at 1440 / 1024 / 768 / 390 / 360 + reduced-motion + no-JS. Claude Code <i>reads the images</i> .
6	Critique	Score against the rubric below, in writing, before touching code again. Name the weakest viewport.
7	Refine	Fix the lowest score first. Re-render. Repeat 5-7 at least three times.
8	Gates	A11y (keyboard, contrast, targets, alt) · Perf (LCP/INP/CLS budgets, weight) · reduced-motion · no-JS · 360px overflow.

The Taste Rubric — ship only at ≥ 4.5 average, no axis below 4:

AXIS	5 LOOKS LIKE
First impression	A creative director assumes a senior human team made it.
Typography	Faces, scale, spacing and figures chosen like a book designer; zero defaults visible.
Composition	Asymmetric confidence; one deliberate grid-break per chapter; varied metre.
Colour & material	Surfaces feel lit and physical; gold reads metallic; photographs share one air.
Motion	Choreographed sentences; reduced-motion still feels designed.
Humanity	Nothing could be mistaken for a template or an AI demo.

ANTI-SLOP LAWS (INSTANT REJECTION)

*Identical card grids · uppercase-mono labels as decoration · pure-black flats · thin-line-everything
· one animation reused site-wide · centered-everything · unmodified component-library aesthetics
· fonts nobody chose.*

Run these in order, one per session step

Prompt A — Typography retrofit

```
Fetch, subset (pyftsubset, latin + kern,liga,onum,tnum,smcp) and embed:
Cormorant Garamond 500/600/500i (display), Newsreader 400/500/400i opsz (text),
Instrument Sans 400/500/600 (UI), IBM Plex Mono 400 (metadata only).
Rebuild the type system on a fluid clamp() scale. Replace every uppercase-mono
label with sentence-case sans or true small-caps. Real quotes and dashes.
Oldstyle figures in prose, tabular-lining in the Ledger. text-wrap:balance on
headings. Then screenshot 1440/390 and show me the type only – no other changes.
```

Prompt B — De-roboticize pass

```
Apply Plan v3 §03-06: warm layered blacks with one key light and corner
vignette; gold-foil gradient inside monumental numerals; ration hairlines to
two per chapter; per-chapter grid-breaks exactly as §04's table; two full-bleed
photographic interludes; one shared duotone grade on all photographs with
edge-dissolve masks; per-moment motion choreography from §06. Keep the scene
engine, spine, and all a11y/perf gates. Screenshot every chapter and self-score
against the Taste Rubric before showing me anything.
```

Prompt C — The loop, enforced

```
Run the Excellence Protocol §07 end-to-end: render 1440/1024/768/390/360 +
reduced-motion + no-JS, write your rubric scores per viewport, fix the lowest
axis, and repeat until every axis ≥4 and average ≥4.5 across three consecutive
cycles. Then run the gates (keyboard path, contrast, targets, LCP/CLS budget,
360px overflow, no-JS readability) and ship with the score sheet.
```

DEFINITION OF DONE

The site is done when it is mistaken for the work of a senior editorial design studio — and still loads in under three seconds on a cheap phone.

- ☐ Fonts fetched, subsetted, embedded — zero external requests preserved
- ☐ All ten §00 corrections verifiably applied
- ☐ Three screenshot-critique cycles logged with scores
- ☐ Gates green: a11y · perf · reduced-motion · no-JS · 360px
- ☐ docs/ updated: asset-inventory · data-sources · launch-checklist